

Whispers Over the Bridge

On a quiet evening in the valley, a small tea stall flickered to life beside an old footbridge. The kettle sang, the river hummed, and the sky wore the last pink ribbon of daylight. Binu wiped the table with the corner of her shawl and set three cups in a neat row—one for herself, one for the first traveler, and one for the story that would surely arrive. Every night the bridge carried footsteps across its wooden ribs, and every night Binu listened, collecting tales the way children collect marbles—bright, round, and comforting in the palm.

Tonight the traveler was a boy with a backpack full of notebooks and a worry folded carefully between the pages. He ordered milk tea, then admitted he was afraid his work would never be good enough—too many ideas, he said, and none of them finished. Binu nodded, as if she had been waiting all week for that exact confession. She told him the bridge never rushed the river; it simply held still and let the water choose its way. Finish one idea, she said softly, the way you finish one cup—warmth first, then the last sweet sip, and only then reach for another.

When the boy left, the cups were empty but the stall felt richer, as if the night itself had tipped a coin into Binu's jar. She closed her eyes and listened: the shuffle of sandals, the distant bicycle bell, the river's low laughter. Somewhere beyond, the city tossed up a scatter of lights, patient as stars. Binu stacked the cups and smiled at the third one—the one for the story—now full again, steeped in courage and steam. Another traveler would come soon, and the bridge would wait, as bridges do, holding the way until someone was ready to cross.